institute Draconian social controls. After the first few self-sustaining communities are established on other worlds, the Earthlings might also be able to relax their strictures and lighten up. The humans in space would provide those on Earth with real protection against rare but catastrophic collisions by asteroids or comets on rogue trajectories. Of course, for this very reason, humans in space would hold the upper hand in any serious dispute with those on Earth.

The prospects of such a time contrast provocatively with forecasts that the progress of science and technology is now near some asymptotic limit; that art, literature, and music are never to approach, much less exceed, the heights our species has, on occasion, already touched; and that political life on Earth is about to settle into some rock-stable liberal democratic world government, identified, after Hegel, as "the end of history." Such an expansion into space also contrasts with a different but likewise discernible trend in recent times—toward authoritarianism, censorship, ethnic hatred, and a deep suspicion of curiosity and learning. Instead, I think that, after some debugging, the settlement of the Solar System presages an open-ended era of dazzling advances in science and technology; cultural flowering; and wide-ranging experiments, up there in the sky, in government and social organization. In more than one respect, exploring the Solar System and homesteading other worlds constitutes the beginning, much more than the end, of history.

IT'S IMPOSSIBLE, for us humans at least, to look into our future, certainly not centuries ahead. No one has ever done so with any consistency and detail. I certainly do not imagine that I can. I have, with some trepidation, gone as far as I have to this point in the book, because we are just recognizing the truly unprecedented challenges brought on by our technology. These challenges have, I think, occasional straightforward implications, some of which I've tried briefly to lay out. There are also less straightforward, much longer-term implications about which I'm even less confident. Nevertheless, I'd like to present them too for your consideration: